Marine Policy

Te Ao Tūroa helps us to care for all coastal and aquatic ecosystems through active kaitiakitanga practice and precautionary, adaptive, integrated stewardship. Doing all we can to support a naturally regenerating ocean is essential to protect its health, provide for us, and assist climate stability. The Green Party will promote Te Tiriti-based governance of the seas of Aotearoa New Zealand to regenerate mauri, prevent damage from human activities, increase resilience to climate change, and support the thriving marine ecosystems that underpin a healthy, well-managed blue economy.

Vision

The ocean's life force and life-supporting capacity are vibrant and vigorous. All human relationships with the marine realm are mutually regenerative.

Values and Principles

- *Honouring Te Tiriti o Waitangi:* Kaitiakitanga, led by tangata whenua, should guide human relationships with the sea, ensuring that it is better cared for. Māori regard all life forms within Te Ao Tūroa as taonga that require appropriate consideration through kawa and tikanga.
- *Ecological Wisdom:* Protecting the mauri, mana, and tapu - the intrinsic vitality, potency, and sanctity of the ocean and of all who dwell within and around it - is fundamental to the enduring life-support system of planet Earth.
- *Social Responsibility:* We should equitably provide for the sustainable livelihoods and recreational and spiritual opportunities valued by New Zealanders that healthy oceans and coasts offer.
- *Appropriate Decision-Making:* A range of interests at both local and national levels must guide decisions concerning coastal and marine management. Decisions must include consideration of the needs of future generations and of the wider environment and ecology.
- *Non-violence*: Human activity should be restorative, not harmful, to the intrinsic mauri, mana, and tapu of all life in the marine environment.
- *Urgency:* Given the biodiversity crisis, the declining health of ocean ecosystems, and climate change impacts such as acidification and increasing sea temperatures, significant increases in investment and pace of implementation are urgently needed to regenerate coastal and marine ecosystems.
- *Interconnection:* Ki uta ki tai - from the mountains to the sea. Marine management requires integrated management of terrestrial and aquatic ecosystems, including the vital role of wetlands in coastal and estuarine zones. The health of people, land, and oceans are inextricably linked.

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Strategic Priorities

The Green Party's strategic goals include:

> *"All our waters will be in transition to becoming clean and able to support healthy ecosystems.*
>
> *All native species and their habitats will be thriving or on a path to recovery in terrestrial, freshwater, and marine environments.*
>
> *Our laws and practices will respect the biological integrity of all life while prioritising the health of indigenous species and ecosystems.*
>
> *The customary and decision-making roles of whānau, hapū, and iwi will be integral to decisions about resource use.*
>
> *Decision-making about resource use will provide for community participation and environmental justice."*

Actions from this policy that work toward these goals include:

- Establish a well-resourced and politically independent Ocean Commission to develop and establish Te Tiriti-based ocean governance of the entire marine area, including the Exclusive Economic Zone, and advise the Government on legislative, policy, and institutional reform. (1.1)
- Reform fisheries and marine protection legislation, including establishing a national, comprehensive, and coherent system of no-take marine protected areas. (2.1.1)
- Supporting the use of marine cultural health indices, shaped by mātauranga Māori, to inform policy, management, and operations. (2.1.4)
- Ending bottom trawling, prioritising seamounts and areas with high levels of sequestered carbon and biodiversity for protection. (5.1.2)

Connected Policies

This policy is one of several that focus on Biodiversity and Environmental Regeneration, alongside Freshwater and Land Use and Soils. The mauri of the oceans is connected to human activity on land, notably Agriculture, Forestry, Housing and Sustainable Communities, and Waste and Hazardous Substances. Climate Change also impacts marine health. For acute marine crisis response, see our Emergency Management Policy. See also our policies on coastal Transport and wave and tidal Energy.

Policy Positions

1. Te Mana o te Moana and Governance

Issues

Marine environmental management in Aotearoa New Zealand is complex legislatively, regulatorily, and practically, and existing frameworks are inconsistently applied. The Māori Fisheries Settlement underpins the Māori economy, but tangata whenua currently have no formal leadership role in ocean management. A lack of up-to-date knowledge about the health of marine environments undermines management planning and operations to address marine issues.

Marine environments face complex challenges, requiring a holistic understanding of the interacting stresses on ecosystems and species.

Actions

1.1. Establish a well-resourced and politically independent Ocean Commission to:

1.1.1. Develop and establish Te Tiriti-based ocean governance of the entire marine area, including the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ); and

1.1.2. Advise the Government on legislative, policy, and institutional reform.

1.2. Establish an Ocean Ministry to implement integrated marine management by:

1.2.1. Implementing Te Tiriti o Waitangi-based policy and operational management;

1.2.2. Enabling kaitiakitanga and the application of mātauranga Māori for all marine activities;

1.2.3. Improving the consistency of environmental management across legislative and administrative marine boundaries (for example, the coastal marine area and the exclusive economic zone);

1.2.4. Contributing to the National Waterways Restoration Strategy, and reviewing relevant national policy direction (such as the New Zealand Coastal Policy Statement and National Policy Statement for Freshwater Management) to improve the water quality of waterways, harbours, and estuaries from whole-of-catchment issues in conjunction with both local government and relevant central government bodies;

1.2.5. Developing and implementing regenerative, ecosystem-based fisheries management plans, in partnership with mana whenua and with fair participation in the process by all stakeholders and the public;

1.2.6. Monitoring and enforcing policy, management, and regulatory implementation;

1.2.7. Establishing and resourcing a Marine Research Council to modernise marine science and inform fisheries management to be future-fit and integrated, and enable the appropriate use of both mātauranga Māori and western science;

1.2.8. Delivering regular and robust reports on the status of ocean and marine ecosystems and on the state of the marine environment;

1.2.9. Establishing environmental and ecological limits that trigger immediate and automatic regulatory action if exceeded;

1.2.10. Resourcing innovative, regenerative marine initiatives, including those by iwi and hāpu and community organisations; and

1.2.11. Exploring with mana whenua the possibility of establishing the rights and personification of the ocean around Aotearoa.

1.3. Retain Aotearoa New Zealand control and utilisation of fisheries in the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ).

A. International Commitments

1.4. Support the leadership of Pacific Island nations on marine environment protection, including international action on:

1.4.1. Building resilience to climate change;

1.4.2. Regenerating ocean ecosystems;

1.4.3. Placing a moratorium on seabed mining in international waters;

1.4.4. Halting seismic prospecting;

1.4.5. Protecting at least 30% of Te Moana-nui-a-Kiwa from fishing and extraction; and

1.4.6. Protecting seamounts from bottom trawling.

1.5. Ratify outstanding international marine agreements, including the Global Oceans Treaty, in consultation with tangata whenua.

1.6. Advocate for the international protection of endangered marine species on the high seas, including expanding the membership and mandate of the International Whaling Commission.

1.7. Ensure all relevant national legislative and regulatory frameworks are aligned with international marine commitments and obligations, and require and resource their enforcement.

2. Marine Biodiversity, Regeneration and Resilience

Issues

The state of the environment and the pressures upon it indicate that humanity must fundamentally reset its relationship with the natural world and foster regeneration in ourselves and nature. Loss of coastal ecosystems, physical disturbance and damage, and fishing catch levels that disrupt ecosystems and risk the health of marine realms for future generations, livelihoods, and rural food security. They also risk undermining Māori fisheries settlement rights, both customary and commercial, and therefore the Māori economy.

Actions

2.1. Reform fisheries and marine protection legislation, including:

2.1.1. Establishing a national, comprehensive, and coherent system of no-take marine protected areas covering an area of at least 30% of the Aotearoa New Zealand territorial sea and at least 30% of the EEZ, with the target percentage and design founded on regenerating mauri and underpinned by mātauranga Māori;

2.1.2. Developing a nationwide mauri-based spatial design for marine and estuarine ecosystem regeneration that incorporates mātauranga Māori and indigenous ecosystem management tikanga, such as taiāpure, mātaitai, and rāhui;

2.1.3. Supporting the application of tikanga Māori and community-based regenerative activities, aiming to restore mauri within marine and estuarine ecosystems;

2.1.4. Supporting the use of marine cultural health indices, shaped by mātauranga Māori, to inform policy, management, and operations; and

2.1.5. Amending the management framework for offshore activities to strengthen protection of the marine environment outside the coastal marine area (12-200 nautical miles offshore).

2.2. Restore native marine flora (muka, salt marshes, mangroves, seagrass, seaweeds, and marine sediments) for regeneration, customary use, and as 'blue carbon' initiatives.

2.3. Collaborate internationally for the maximum possible protection of threatened marine species, including by:

2.3.1. Developing international species recovery plans for all threatened marine and migratory species;

2.3.2. Targeting zero global fisheries bycatch of seabirds, turtles, and marine mammals;

2.3.3. Opposing all commercial and research-oriented whaling, and supporting South Pacific and regional whale sanctuaries; and

2.3.4. Opposing marine mammals being held in captivity except as part of an approved threatened species recovery strategy.

2.4. Ensure that commercial marine operations contribute to marine regeneration and resilience, by:

2.4.1. Establishing appropriate financial mechanisms (e.g., resource rentals) to charge for private commercial use or occupation of public coastal and marine space; and

2.4.2. Requiring marine-based industrial activities to pay a bond covering predicted and potential decommissioning and restoration costs, before operations commence.

3. The Marine Environment in a Changing Climate

Issues

Climate change further threatens indigenous marine species and ecosystems. It shifts the natural population range of some species, often with unpredictable and cascading ecological consequences. Global warming causes algal blooms, deoxygenation, and species loss. In addition, the increasing level of carbon dioxide absorbed by the ocean causes acidification, which affects the ability of marine species to build shells and skeletons. This includes plankton, which are the foundation of marine food webs, threatening entire ecosystems. Finally, melting Arctic and Antarctic ice sheets are now affecting ocean currents critical to climate and temperature moderation.

Actions

3.1. Fully incorporate the role of a regenerating ocean in the national strategic response to climate change, including by:

3.1.1. Developing a national blue carbon calculation and assessment capability (including marine flora regeneration, marine permaculture, and polytrophic aquaculture) for use in carbon pricing mechanisms.

3.2. Facilitate resilience and adaptation as marine ecosystems move and adapt to climate change, including by:

3.2.1. Researching and addressing the impacts of climate change on threatened marine species, prioritising those endemic to Aotearoa New Zealand; and

3.2.2. Protecting buffer areas from subdivision and development to leave room for coastal and estuarine ecosystems to move inland with rising sea levels.

4. Marine Damage Prevention

Issues

Marine pollution ranges from micro- and macro-plastics to chemicals and wastewater carried into the sea by rivers and failing water infrastructure. Bio-accumulation of microplastics, heavy metals, and pollutants has been recorded in fish, shellfish, seabirds, marine mammals, and humans. The long shape of the country, its position between significant oceans and the Tasman Sea, soil types, and poor land-use practices all contribute to very high levels of coastal sediment, which smothers coastal habitats. Sediment is also continuously resuspended by bottom-contacting fishing gear and sea-mining activities, choking marine life. This is exacerbated by coastal and urban flooding.

Actions

4.1. Halt activities that significantly contribute to the degradation of marine and estuarine habitats, including:

4.1.1. Identifying and addressing coastal dumping and other sources of marine pollution (point and non-point sources); and

4.1.2. Prohibiting seabed mining and seismic prospecting for oil and gas within Aotearoa New Zealand's territorial sea and EEZ.

4.2. Reduce the risk of pollutants entering aquatic ecosystems by:

4.2.1. Enforcing international maritime pollution legislation (MARPOL), to which Aotearoa New Zealand is a signatory;

4.2.2. Excluding from sensitive marine environments ships that carry significant amounts of oil;

4.2.3. Requiring oil and chemical tankers entering Aotearoa New Zealand's territorial waters to be double-hulled; and

4.2.4. Resourcing marine biosecurity operations, including risk assessment, surveillance, and incursion response.

5. Fisheries and Aquaculture

Issues

Aotearoa New Zealand fisheries management is falling behind international developments. Across many species, fish numbers and fish sizes are declining. Bottom trawling and dredging destroy sensitive ecosystems and release carbon sequestered in ocean sediment.

Actions

5.1. Reform the Fisheries Act 1996 and its subsequent amendments to enable Tiriti- and ecosystem-based management of all fisheries, including:

5.1.1. Transitioning the Quota Management System (QMS) to an ecosystem-based approach that enables the interactions of all species, their environment, and the interactions between trophic levels to be addressed in management to ensure fish, shellfish, and associated and dependent species populations are maintained at ecologically healthy, resilient levels;

5.1.2. Ending bottom trawling, prioritising seamounts and areas with high levels of sequestered carbon and biodiversity; and

5.1.3. Ending the fishing-related mortality of marine mammals, turtles, seabirds, and other protected marine species for all fisheries.

5.2. Ensure that commercial fishing occurs within agreed take areas and minimises ecological impacts, including by:

5.2.1. Supporting all commercial fisheries to transition to independently-verified best practice methods and equipment.

5.2.2. Implementing innovative, detailed, and effective incentives and penalties to avoid bycatch of protected and threatened marine species.

5.2.3. Strengthening the monitoring and enforcement of fishing regulations, including recreational fishing and monitoring of commercial fisheries,

5.3. Ensure that recreational fishing regulations address cumulative and long-term ecological effects and avoid harm to protected species, including by:

5.3.1. Investigating recreational fishing licensing and innovative use of licensing revenue; and

5.3.2. Encouraging self-reporting of recreational fishing activity to inform bag limits.

5.4. Minimise ghost fishing gear, including by:

5.4.1. Mandating gear marking to promote responsible ownership;

5.4.2. Providing adequate recovery and disposal facilities for old gear and improving seabed mapping to help avoid broken gear; and

5.4.3. Phasing out the use of synthetic plastic ropes.

5.5. Improve the viability of small commercial fishers in the inshore fleet, including by:

5.5.1. Reviewing the operation of the QMS to improve the viability of small inshore fishers to provide New Zealanders with verifiably sustainable seafood;

5.5.2. Investigating opportunities for developing quota in a local pool that can only be owned within a specific geographical area;

5.5.3. Revising cost recovery and administration charges so that costs are more proportional to the commercial benefit derived from the fishery; and

5.5.4. Supporting responsible fisheries education, training and credentialing.

5.6. Enable the farming of marine species, including kelp, in ways that support ecosystem health, including by:

5.6.1. Promoting the use of marine permaculture and polytrophic aquaculture, without the introduction of artificial feed.

6. Connection with the Marine Environment

Issues

Much of the population of Aotearoa New Zealand lives close to the ocean, and it plays a significant role in national identity. However, access to the marine environment is inequitable and not readily possible for many children. There are too few protected places where New Zealanders can experience the marine ecosystem in an undamaged and natural state. As a result, knowledge of the past abundance of the moana is being lost over time.

Actions

6.1. Support programmes to build a connection with the marine environment and ocean, including:

6.1.1. Developing and delivering cross-cultural ocean literacy so that all people of Aotearoa can learn to understand, care for, and love the ocean;

6.1.2. Supporting adult and child learn-to-swim and diving programmes, learn-to-sail programmes, and opportunities to visit marine reserves;

6.1.3. Enhancing and promoting education, training, and research in marine sciences, and other capability-building opportunities;

6.1.4. Supporting non-extractive marine-based recreation and tourism activities; and

6.1.5. Investing in mātauranga Māori as it pertains to the moana.